FREE SOCIAL STORY

Blue Cat Learns About Public and Private

A short story about Blue Cat and Pink Cat in Respectville, with a sorting game and a mini poster for home and class.

WHO IT IS FOR
Autistic children aged about 4 to 9, with the parents, carers, teachers and SNAs who read it with them.

NCCA STAGE
Primary (infants to 2nd class) · Special classes

Easy read

Some places are public. Some places are private. Some body parts are private. I keep private things private.

How to use this resource

- Read the story with your child at a calm time, one page at a time. Stop whenever your child wants to.
- Read it more than once. Repeat the **same words** at home and at school: **'That is private. Bedroom or bathroom.'**
- Cut out the sorting cards on pages 6 and 7. Sort them on the board on page 5. Say each answer out loud.
- Put the mini poster on page 8 up in the classroom or bedroom. Stick in photos of your own rooms.

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Version 1.0 · blue-cat-public-and-private

Blue Cat's story

Blue Cat lives in Respectville with his twin sister Pink Cat, and their family. In Respectville, people tell you clearly what is OK and what is not. This story is about public and private.



This is Blue Cat. He lives in Respectville.



Pink Cat is his twin sister. They live with Mum and Dad.



Today Blue Cat is learning about public and private.

Public places



A public place is a place where lots of people can be.



Blue Cat's classroom is public. His teacher and friends are there.



The park is public. The shop is public. The bus is public.



The kitchen and sitting room at home are public too. The whole family uses them.

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Private places

A private place is a place where I can be on my own.

Blue Cat's bedroom is private when the door is closed.

The bathroom is private. Blue Cat locks the door.

A toilet cubicle at school is private. The door is locked.

Pink Cat knocks before she opens a closed door. Blue Cat knocks too.

Private body parts

Blue Cat's body parts under his underwear are private.

Private parts are the penis and testicles, the vulva and vagina, the bottom, and for some bodies the breasts.

Private parts stay covered in public. Blue Cat keeps his clothes on.

A doctor or nurse may need to look. A parent or trusted carer is there, and they explain first.

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Private things in private places



Using the toilet is private. Blue Cat does it in the bathroom.



Having a shower and getting dressed are private. Blue Cat does them in the bathroom or his bedroom.



Touching my own private parts is private. It is for a private place, like my bedroom.



If Blue Cat forgets, Mum says: 'That is private. Bedroom or bathroom.' Blue Cat is not in trouble.

Public and private on the internet



The internet is public. Lots of people can see it.



A photo online is public. Blue Cat does not share photos of private parts.



Blue Cat does not tell strangers private things, like where he lives or his password.



If someone asks for a private photo, Blue Cat tells an adult he trusts.

The end

Blue Cat knows the difference now. **Private things happen in private places.** He feels safe and calm. Well done, Blue Cat!

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Sorting game: sort board

Cut out the cards on the next pages. Read each card. Put it in the Public box or the Private box.

Public

Put cards here

Private

Put cards here

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Sorting cards: places and actions

Answers are on page 7 in the adult notes. Say it out loud: **'Public'** or **'Private'**.



Classroom

Public or private?

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My bedroom, door closed

Public or private?

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Park

Public or private?

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Bathroom, door locked

Public or private?

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Shop

Public or private?

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Toilet cubicle, door locked

Public or private?

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Sorting cards: body parts and actions



Taking off my clothes

Public or private?

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Having a shower

Public or private?

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Posting a photo online

Public or private?

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Saying hello to a friend

Public or private?

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My private parts

Public or private?

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Touching my own private parts

Public or private?

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Notes for adults: answers and tips

- **Public:** classroom, park, shop, posting online, saying hello. **Private:** bedroom with the door closed, locked bathroom, locked cubicle, taking off clothes, having a shower, my private parts, touching my own private parts (in a private place only).
- Some answers depend on the setting. 'Posting a photo online' is public: once it is online, many people can see it.
- If your child gets one 'wrong', say the right answer calmly and move on. There is no shame in learning.
- Use the same words at home, school and in any respite or residential setting. Teach it before you need it, not only after something has happened.
- Some children share a bedroom. Agree a private place and a private time with them, for example the bathroom or a closed-door time.
- Touching their own body is normal and healthy. The teaching is where, not whether. Respond calmly, without shame: 'That is private. Bedroom or bathroom.'

Mini poster: public and private at home and in class

Stick a photo of a room in each box, or draw it. Write the name. Tick public or private. Use it as a poster in the classroom or bedroom.

Photo of room

Name: _____ ☐ Public ☐ Private

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Photo of room

Name: _____ ☐ Public ☐ Private

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Photo of room

Name: _____ ☐ Public ☐ Private

© autismandme.ie

Photo of room

Name: _____ ☐ Public ☐ Private

© autismandme.ie

Photo of room

Name: _____ ☐ Public ☐ Private

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Photo of room

Name: _____ ☐ Public ☐ Private

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Private things happen in private places.

In public, I keep my clothes on.

I can ask a trusted adult if I am not sure.

Curriculum links

NCCA and Department of Education alignment

- Primary SPHE (1999), strand **Myself**, strand unit *Taking care of my body* and *Safety and protection*; supported by the Stay Safe programme.
- A new Primary Wellbeing specification is being developed under the Primary Curriculum Framework (2023).
- NCCA guidance on RSE for students with special educational needs: teach public and private explicitly, with visual supports, and keep the language the same at home and school.

Universal Design for Learning

Every Autism & Me resource offers more than one way in: pictures and words together, an easy-read line, things to do with your hands, and scripts to practise. Keep the learning aim the same for everyone, and change the route. No diagnosis is needed to use any support in this resource.

Getting support in Ireland

Emergency

112 or 999 — Gardaí, ambulance or fire. Use it if someone is in danger now.

Childline (ISPCC)

Free, 24 hours: phone 1800 66 66 66, text 50101, or chat at childline.ie. For anyone under 18.

Tusla – Child and Family Agency

Report a worry about a child's safety to your local Tusla social work duty team. Contacts at tusla.ie.

Parentline

Support for parents and carers: 01 873 3500, parentline.ie.

Your school

Talk to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP) for child safeguarding, a class tutor or year head.

Autism & Me

Questions about this resource or training for your school: contactautismandme@gmail.com · autismandme.ie

If a child tells you something worrying

Stay calm. Listen, and believe them. Do not promise to keep it a secret. Write down what they said in their own words, with the date. Pass it on the same day: in a school, to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP); otherwise to Tusla. If anyone is in immediate danger, call 112 or 999. Follow *Children First: National Guidance for the Protection and Welfare of Children* (2017).

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